

# Notes from visit by Ruth Todd, architectural historian

## 353 N. Claremont Street

July 17, 2014

### Goals

- Identify the architectural details that are original and should be preserved.
- Advise about how best to preserve and restore the original architectural details.
- In places where the original architectural details have been modified or removed, speculate as to what the original work might have looked like.
- Advise about how best to remove non-original elements (such as fixtures, doors, and hardware) and replace them with period appropriate elements (antiques salvaged from other homes, where possible; quality reproductions if antiques are not available).
- Work to ensure that everything is done in keeping with the Secretary of the Interior's Standards for Rehabilitation of Historic Properties.

### Bedroom questions

- Do you think the bedrooms would have originally had picture rails? [maybe]
- Do you think the bedroom closet doors are original? [Ruth assumes that the two closet doors are either original or were added soon after the house was built. We could check to see if the closets are original by punching a small hole in the 8' closet ceiling and looking to see if the 10' ceiling above is finished. If the closets are not original, the space for them was taken from the front bedroom.]
- We believe that in the back bedroom, the west-side wall may have been moved a few feet to east. Is there any way to figure out whether or not the west wall is original, or where the original wall might have been? If the wall was moved, it means that the bathroom used to be smaller – if so, do you think it was originally a bathroom, and what fixtures do you think were in it? [Ruth did not have a suggestion for figuring out if the wall was original. Ruth did not have a guess about what would have originally been in the space where the bathroom now is.]

### Window questions

- Do you think the kitchen and the back bedroom originally had window pairs that matched the pairs in the dining room and front bedroom? If so, would the

windows in the bedroom have been centered along the outside wall? (In 1995 an architect who studied the bedroom window wrote, *"It is my opinion that a pair of windows were originally located in the center of this wall and were replaced with the existing configuration at a much later date."* – H Ruth Todd, AIA) [Yes, the kitchen and back bedroom would both originally have had windows pairs that matched the pairs in the dining room and front bedroom. Standing in the back bedroom, the windows would have been roughly centered in the interior wall. If we replace the windows, we'll want to center them in the wall, so that location will depend on whether or not we move (or remove) the non-original wall between the bedroom and bathroom.]

- Do you think all of the colored glass squares in the living room windows are original? If not, any suggestions about what to do about it? [Most of the glass squares look like they are original. Some look darker and might be newer, including the lower left yellow square in the left window. A company called Bendheim sells restoration glass. Mike Rice is an opening consultant at [openingconsultantsinc.com](http://openingconsultantsinc.com)]
- Any suggestions for us about window blinds or curtains for the bedrooms? We're considering wood slat blinds, or more likely top-down-bottom-up shades that would provide privacy but still let in light. [Eyelet lace curtains, like what we have already, or a single or dual panel of curtains (optionally with a roller shade hidden behind to make it dark at night), or a roman shade, or shutters. Not top-down-bottom-up shades.]

## Woodwork questions

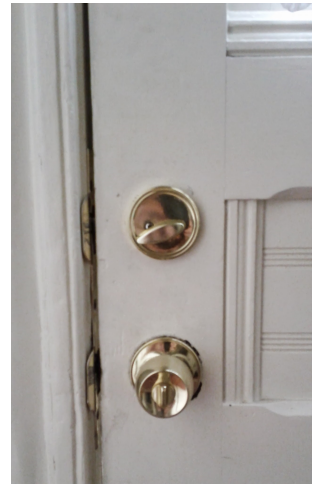
- What's the best way to figure out what type of wood was used to make the windows, doors, baseboards, picture rails, interior window frames, exterior window frames, front porch railing, etc.? [Do you have any reason to think that the shingles are not redwood? If not, then I would assume they are redwood.]
- Would the interior woodwork have originally been painted, or might the wood have been varnished or stained? [It was probably originally varnished (shellacked). If you sand lightly, in circles, you can sand down through the layers and get back to the original layer. We could strip just the doors, rather than all the woodwork, if we can't afford to do everything.]
- Would the door hinges and window locks have originally been painted? [Yes.]

## Door questions

- Do you think the front door would have originally had separate “lites” in the window? [Maybe. Hard to tell.]
- What sort of doorknob, lock, and trim plates would be appropriate for the front door? (Would our salvaged trim plate with two keyholes be a good choice?) [We should do a Google search on “Sargent and Company 496A”, the text on the back of the trim plate with two keyholes. We did that search, and couldn't find any Sargent trim plates, although we did find doorbells, mail slots, and some bin pulls that look quite similar to the bin pulls from the dining room.]
- What sort of mailbox would be appropriate? [Don't know. You could do research on how mail was delivered in San Mateo at the time.]
- What sort of doorbell, if any, would be appropriate? [Didn't ask.]
- For the interior doors, any suggestions about where to get trim plates and mortise boxes? [No specific answer.]
- What would be an appropriate choice for a replacement for the back door? Would our salvaged door be a good choice? [Yes, that would look nice.]



*Trim plate with two keyholes, for front door*



*Hardware on the front door*



*Replacement back door to be refurbished*

## Living room questions

- Would wallpaper be appropriate for the living room? For other rooms as well? [Don't know.]

## Dining room questions

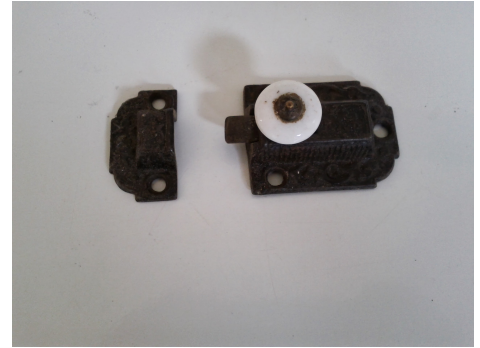
- Do you think the fireplace hearth and mantel are original? Do you think the back wall of the firebox is original? [She thought our assessment was plausible, that the hearth and mantel are original.]
- Do you think the bin-pull handles and cupboard latch we have belong to the dining room cupboard? [Yes, for both the bin pulls and the cupboard latch.]



*Bin pull handles*



*Dining room cupboard*



*Cupboard latch*

## Light fixture questions

- Do you think the plaster ceiling medallions in the living room and dining room are original? [The ceiling medallions may have been added when the house was first wired for electricity, perhaps sometime when the house was still fairly new. The house may not have had chandeliers before then.]
- We believe that neither gas service nor electricity were available in this neighborhood at the time the house was built. (The house was built in 1891. In 1892, the San Mateo Gas Light Company was incorporated, and sometime in the mid 1890s an electric light company was formed. San Mateo resident D. Gordon Bromfield later recalled that electricity in the early years was unreliable, and few families used it rather than oil lamps for lighting.) Do you think the house would have originally had kerosene light fixtures? [The house may not have had chandeliers originally, and they may have been added after the house was wired for electricity. Gasoliers would be an appropriate choice. The house might have originally had kerosene chandeliers, but we should be careful not to get ones that are too big for the scale of the rooms.]
- Do you think the house might have had gas lighting at some point? Would there be any way to look for signs of gas pipes in the walls that would have fed wall sconces? [...we didn't ask this...]

- Do you think the dining room light fixture might have been original to one of the bedrooms? [Maybe. It would certainly be appropriate in one of the bedrooms.]

- Which rooms would have originally had light fixtures – living room, dining room, entrance hall, bedrooms, front porch, kitchen, bathroom? [...we didn't ask this...]

- What sorts of fixtures would be best as replacements now? Would “library chandeliers” be appropriate in the bedrooms? Would four-arm chandeliers be appropriate in the living room and dining room? What would be best for the entrance hall, front porch, kitchen, bathrooms, back hall, laundry room? [...we didn't ask this...]

- Do you think it would be appropriate to replace the current plastic light switches with reproductions of early-1900s push-button switches? (See the push-button face plate that we found in the house.) [Yes, replace with push-button switches, or keep the switches and just replace the plastic face plates. Maybe try to get something ornate that matches the spirit of the door hinges and other hardware.]



*The kerosene "library chandelier" currently in the dining room*



*An example of a kerosene fixture that might be appropriate for the living room or dining room*

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*Early 1900s push-button light switches*

## Kitchen questions

- Do you think the kitchen originally had a fireplace? [No, not necessarily.]
- Do you think the beadboard in the pantry is original? [Yes, probably.]
- Do you think beadboard siding would be appropriate throughout the kitchen, bathrooms, and laundry room? If so, how tall should it be (e.g., 3 feet vs. 5 feet)?

[Yes. In the pantry, we could try to remove the layer of plaster that's over the beadboard, and figure out how tall the beadboard originally was. We could also have beadboard on the cabinet fronts.]

- Would the kitchen have originally had a bare wood floor? [Yes, or wood with a linoleum finish. We could look for “marmoleum” as a replacement.]
- Would the kitchen originally have had 10-foot ceilings like the rest of the house? [Probably.] Could we consider installing a decorative tin ceiling in the kitchen, or would that be inappropriate? [We could have a beadboard ceiling if we wanted.] What about crown molding? [...we didn't ask this...]
- If we wanted to add skylights above the kitchen sink, is there some sort of Victorian skylight or light box that might be appropriate? [Yes. Keep it simple. Raise the kitchen ceiling where possible, then have it slope, and have a spoked skyline in the slope. Or, keep the kitchen ceiling as it is, and have a skylight and a lay light. Or, enlarge the sink window to go as high as it can, and continue glass into new sloped roof with two matching skylights on either side, with cabinets underneath.]
- Would subway tile be appropriate for the kitchen countertop backspash? [Yes, or beadboard.]
- We are considering replacing the fridge with something built to resemble a wooden ice box, and replacing the stove with a reproduction stove from Elmira Stove Works. Any thoughts? Is that a nice compromise at historical accuracy, or would that just muddle things up? [That would look beautiful.]



*Reproduction stove from  
Elmira Stove Works*



*Fridge with icebox paneling*

## Bathroom questions

- Piped water was available in the neighborhood when the house was built, but we don't know anything about sewer lines. What sort of plumbing fixtures might the house have originally had? [There would probably have been no plumbing until the teens.]
- Would a tile floor be appropriate in the bathroom, and if so, what sort of tile? [Yes, tile or linoleum.]
- Would beadboard or “subway tile” be appropriate for the walls in the bathroom? [Yes.]
- We're thinking of putting in a claw-foot tub and a pedestal sink. Any suggestions about those or other details (medicine cabinet, towel racks, toilet paper holder)? [...we didn't ask this...]

## Fire protection questions

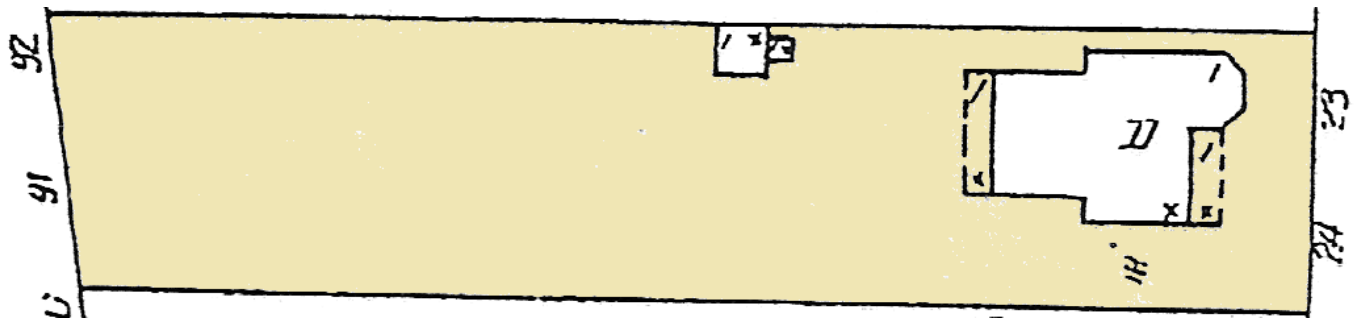
- Would you recommend installing a fire sprinkler system, or is that likely to do as much harm as good? [This is more common in larger public buildings.]
- In the California Historical Building Code, in the chapter on Fire Protection, they talk about wood lath and plaster walls, and discuss filling interior walls with “mineral fiber or glass fiber.” Would you recommend doing that? Is that something we could consider doing for exterior walls as well, or is that not possible? [We could put in bat insulation, which is mostly used for thermal insulation but which might help slow the spread of a fire.]

## Attic questions

- What sort of shingles would the roof originally have had? Is there any way to know how old the existing wood shingles are? [The existing wood shingles might actually be original.]
- What would be the best replacement for the current roof – something better than plywood panels and asphalt shingles? [It might be worth trying to keep the layer of original shingles, and put the plywood panels on top of that.]

## Back porch questions

- What do you think the original back porch might have looked like? Would it have had a roof? Would the railing have matched the one on the front porch? Would the stairs have been at the center of the porch and faced the back of the lot?



*1901 Sanborn Map*

## Exterior questions

- Do you think downspout conductor box at the north corner is original? If so, do you think the other downspouts would have had matching conductor boxes? [The house probably would not have had gutters or downspouts at all. If it did have downspouts, they would have been round, and made of copper. The conductor box doesn't have a round downspout and probably is not original.]



*Conductor box on north corner downspout*

## Contractor questions

- Any suggestions about finding contractors who do this sort of work on historic house? [Ask at Ohmega Salvage for recommendations about people to strip the doors that we have in the garage. Ask at the planning department for a list of the contractors who have worked on historic buildings. Try asking at the Burlingame planning department as well as the San Mateo planning department. Try asking the California Preservation Foundation in San Francisco if they know of any “residential preservation contractors” who work on the peninsula. The executive director is Cindy Heightsman. Yvonne will answer the phone, and we should tell her Ruth Todd suggested we call.] [Other good resources are the Old House Journal, and the Rejuvenation catalog.]